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• defining knowledge

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• THE PROBLEM OF THE CRITERION

Anyone who wishes to offer a definition of knowledge – who wishes to say what knowledge is – faces an immediate problem, which is how to begin. Now it might seem as if the answer here is obvious, in that one should start simply by looking at the cases in which one has knowledge and considering what is common to each case. So, for example, one might think of such paradigm cases of knowledge acquisition as the scientist who, upon conducting her experiments, correctly determines the chemical structure of the substance before her, or the 'star' witness in the murder trial who knows that the defendant is guilty of the murder because she saw him do it in clear daylight. The thought is that all one needs to do is determine what is common to each of these paradigm cases and one will be well on one's way to discerning what knowledge is.

The problem with this suggestion, however, is that if one doesn't already know what knowledge is (i.e. what the defining characteristics, or *criteria*, of knowledge are), how can one correctly identify cases of knowledge in the first place? After all, one cannot simply assume that one knows what the criteria for knowledge are without thereby taking a definition of knowledge for granted from the outset. But, equally, neither is it plausible to suppose that we can correctly identify instances of knowledge without assuming knowledge of such criteria, since without a prior grasp of these criteria how are we supposed to tell what is a genuine case of knowledge and what isn't?

This difficulty regarding defining knowledge is known as the **problem of the criterion**, and it dates right back to antiquity. We can roughly summarise the problem in terms of the following two claims:

- 1 I can only identify instances of knowledge provided I already know what the criteria for knowledge are.
- 2 I can only know what the criteria for knowledge are provided I am already able to identify instances of knowledge.

We thus seem to be trapped inside a very small circle of unpleasant options. I must either assume that I can independently know what the criteria for knowledge are in order to identify instances of knowledge, or else I must assume that I can identify instances of knowledge in order to determine what the criteria for knowledge are. Either way, the dubious nature of the assumption in question appears to call the legitimacy of the epistemological project of defining knowledge into dispute.

Roderick Chisholm (1916–99)

We start with particular cases of knowledge and then from those we generalise and formulate criteria [which tell] us what it is for a belief to be epistemologically respectable.

Chisholm, *The Foundations of Knowing*

The American philosopher Roderick Chisholm was without doubt the most influential epistemologist of the second half of the twentieth century. A good deal of his influence is due to his best-selling textbook on epistemology, *Theory of Knowledge*, which was first published in 1966 (a third edition came out in 1989) and which quickly became a standard text in this area throughout the world. His influence is also felt through his students – such as Keith Lehrer and Ernest Sosa – who have gone on to become very prominent philosophers in their own right.

Central to Chisholm's contribution to epistemology is a commitment to epistemic internalism and a version of classical foundationalism. In addition, he published important work in epistemology on such areas as the problem of the criterion and the epistemology of perception. Chisholm also made significant contributions to other areas of philosophy, such as metaphysics and ethics.

• METHODISM AND PARTICULARISM

Although the problem of the criterion dates right back to antiquity, the contemporary focus on it is due almost entirely to the work done on this problem by the American philosopher Roderick Chisholm (1916–99). As he noted, historically, philosophers have tended to begin by assuming that they already know – or at least are able to identify through philosophical reflection alone – what the criteria for knowledge are, and have proceeded on this basis to examine the issue of whether or not we have any knowledge. Chisholm calls such a stance **methodism**, and

cites as a famous example of a methodist the French philosopher René Descartes (1596–1650), whom we will hear more about in the next chapter.

In contrast to methodism, Chisholm argues that we should grip the other horn of the dilemma and adopt a position that he calls **particularism**. According to particularism, rather than assuming that one can identify the criteria for knowledge independently of examining any particular instances of knowledge, one should instead assume that one can correctly identify particular instances of knowledge and proceed on this basis to determine what the criteria for knowledge are.

There is much to be said both for and against these two positions. One of the main advantages of methodism is that it doesn't begin by assuming the falsity of **scepticism** (i.e. the worry that we might not know anything much at all), since it leaves it an open question whether there is anything that meets the criteria for knowledge. The big problem facing the view, however, is that it just seems plain mysterious how we are to get a grip on the criteria for knowledge without appealing to particular instances of knowledge.

Persuaded by this sort of objection to methodism, most epistemologists have followed Chisholm in opting for particularism instead. In favour of particularism is the thought that if one has to assume anything in this regard (as seemingly we must, given the problem of the criterion), it is far less extravagant to suppose that we can correctly identify particular cases of knowledge independently of any prior awareness of what the criteria for knowledge are than to suppose that we can identify what the criteria for knowledge are without prior appeal to cases of knowledge. Unsurprisingly, those sympathetic to scepticism will balk at the particularist methodology since they will argue that the claim that we do indeed possess knowledge is something that has to be *shown*, not assumed.

Notice that the problem of the criterion might not be so pressing if the criteria for knowledge were entirely obvious, since if they were, then the assumption – key to methodism – that we can know what the criteria for knowledge are independently of examining any particular instances of knowledge (by simply reflecting on the concept of knowledge, say) would not be nearly so implausible. The difficulty, however, is that reflection itself indicates that there is no simple account of the criteria for knowledge available.

For example, we saw in Chapter 1 that it is certainly the case that if one is to know a proposition, then one had better have a true belief in that proposition. If knowledge required only true belief, then we might be entitled to think that so obvious a set of criteria for knowledge could be determined without making use of any putative instances of knowledge (though note that we have already begun to illicitly bring examples into our discussion, so this claim is far from uncontentious). In this way, we might be able to weaken the force of the problem of the criterion.

The problem, however, as we also saw in Chapter 1, is that knowledge demands much more than mere true belief. Moreover, as we will now see, specifying just what it demands in this regard is notoriously difficult. Accordingly, even if this

strategy of claiming that the criteria for knowledge are manifest could work in principle (which is far from obvious), it won't work in practice for the simple reason that the criteria for knowledge are manifestly *not* manifest at all.

• KNOWLEDGE AS JUSTIFIED TRUE BELIEF

We noted in Chapter 1 that knowledge cannot just be true belief since one can, for example, gain a true belief in all manner of bizarre and inappropriate ways, and in such cases one would not think that one had knowledge. Think again about our gambler from Chapter 1, Harry, who forms his belief about which horse will win the race by considering which horse's name most appeals to him. Even if the horse does go on to win the race, so that Harry's belief is true, he clearly did not know that this would happen.

So it seems that there must be more to knowledge than just true belief. But what could this additional component be? The natural answer to this question, one that is often ascribed to Plato, is that what is needed is a *justification* for one's belief, where this is understood as being in possession of good reasons for thinking that what one believes is true. This proposal is known as the **classical account of knowledge**. It is also sometimes referred to as the 'tripartite' (i.e. three-part) account of knowledge.

Back in Chapter 1, we contrasted Harry with a 'Mr Big' who bases his belief that Lucky Lass will win on excellent grounds, for he has fixed the race by drugging the other horses. That justification is the missing ingredient in our account of knowledge certainly seems to accord with the cases of Harry and Mr Big, since what the former lacks, but the latter possesses, is the ability to offer good reasons in favour of his belief, and this is just what being justified intuitively involves. It is thus plausible to contend that knowledge is simply justified true belief and, while this isn't as straightforward an analysis as one which held that knowledge is merely true belief, it is fairly simple. Perhaps we could determine that these were the criteria for knowledge by reflection alone without difficulty.

• GETTIER CASES

Unfortunately, matters are not nearly so straightforward. The reason for this is that this classical theory of knowledge has itself been shown to be completely untenable. The person who illustrated this was a philosopher named Edmund Gettier who, in a three-page article, offered a devastating set of counter-examples to the classical account: what are now known as **Gettier cases**. In essence, what Gettier showed was that you could have a justified true belief and yet still lack knowledge of what you believe because your true belief was ultimately gained via luck in much the same way as Harry's belief was gained by luck.

